

Simple tips for a greener lifestyle

12-15 minuti

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Green tips

Small changes can add up to big climate results



A cleaner way to clean



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If your washing machine has a setting for the amount of clothing you're washing, choose a low setting—you'll use less water and your clothes will get just as clean.

Use less hot water. Washing your clothes in cold water uses about one-tenth of the energy as washing in hot water.¹

The average washing machine uses about 31 gallons of water per load, whereas newer, high-efficiency models use as little as 13 gallons of water per load.

Did you know?

Many dry cleaners in the US use perchloroethylene, a solvent that has been linked to cancer, nervous system damage, and hormonal disruption. Seek out a non-toxic professional dry cleaning alternative or "green cleaner" in your area.

A bright idea



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Make it a habit to turn off the lights when you leave any room for 15 minutes or more. Consider using controls such as timers that automatically turn off lights when you're not using them and dimmers that use lower light levels.

Don't forget about natural lighting! Light-filtering curtains and shades can let in sunlight while maintaining privacy.

Did you know?

Light-emitting diodes—also known as LEDs—use up to 90% less energy and last 25 times longer than incandescent lightbulbs².

A home run



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Heating uses more energy and costs more money than any other system in your home, typically making up about 29% of your utility bill. You can save about 30%³ by maintaining heating equipment and upgrading to recommended insulation, air sealing, and thermostat settings—all while reducing environmental emissions!

Choose low-toxic paints that are low in volatile organic compounds (VOCs), which can irritate the lungs and cause allergic reactions. Zero-VOC paints are also available.

If using solid wood for a project, select products with the [Forest Stewardship Council label](#), certifying the wood was responsibly grown and harvested. Or find salvaged wood products at local used-building materials retailers.

Did you know?

A leaky faucet that drips at a rate of one drop per second can waste more than an estimated 3,000 gallons of water per year.

Waste not



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Recycling 1 ton of paper saves 7,000 gallons of water, three cubic yards of landfill space, and 4,100 kilowatt-hours of electricity.

Reuse containers and reduce waste. The average child's school lunch generates 67 pounds of packaging waste over a year.

Batteries can cause serious harm to human health and the environment when disposed of with municipal solid waste. Many companies and retailers will take your old batteries and properly dispose of them or have them recycled.

Did you know?

Polystyrene ("Styrofoam") is difficult to recycle, both because recycling facilities aren't commonplace and you can't make it into new high-quality polystyrene.

In the US alone, it is estimated that the annual volume of plastic waste produced is over 42 million metric tons, only 8.7% of which is recycled.

About a third of all the food produced globally is never eaten. If

we stop wasting food, we can reduce around 6%-8% of all human-caused greenhouse gas emissions. With some planning and small steps in preparation, storage, and freezing, you can make great strides to decrease waste in your kitchen at home and save money, too.

In the US alone, producing food we lose or waste generates the equivalent of 32.6 million cars' worth of greenhouse gas emissions. If you've got some small outdoor space, consider starting a compost bin, or see if there are community options nearby to drop off your inedible scraps or peelings.

Did you know?

Twenty-six recycled PET plastic bottles equal a polyester suit. Five recycled PET bottles make enough fiberfill to stuff a ski jacket.

Now you're cooking!



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Use a microwave to save energy. Microwave ovens use around 50% less energy than conventional ovens do.

Did you know?

Generating enough electricity to cook for an hour in a standard electric oven creates 2.7 pounds of CO₂. A toaster oven creates 1.3 pounds over 50 minutes; a microwave creates 0.5 pounds over 15 minutes.

Today's dishwashers are about 95% more energy-efficient than those bought in 1972—your old dishwasher may be costing you more in energy bills than it would take to buy a new one.

Did you know?

Efficient dishwashers use only 3.2 gallons of water per cycle. Washing dishes by hand wastes significantly more water than an efficient dishwasher. With the right dishwasher and detergent, you can skip the rinse and scrape your dishes before loading them in the dishwasher.

Down the drain



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Older showerheads can use 2.5 gallons per minute or more.

New, efficient models use 2 gallons per minute or fewer. By replacing just one showerhead with a WaterSense-labeled model, the [US EPA estimates](#) the average family can save 2,700 gallons of water, the amount of electricity needed to power its home for 11 days, and more than \$75 in energy and water costs every year.

You can save as much as 3,000 gallons of water per year by turning off the tap when you brush your teeth.

A full bathtub requires between 40 gallons and 70 gallons of water; take a shower instead to save water and energy!

[Learn more about what you can do to stop water pollution.](#)

Did you know?

If your toilet is from 1992 or earlier, you probably have an inefficient model that uses between 3.5 gallons to seven gallons per flush. Newer, high-efficiency toilets use less than 1.3 gallons per flush.

See the forest for the trees



Consider switching to e-billing. In the US, paper products make up the largest percentage of municipal solid waste, and hard copy bills alone generate almost 2 million tons of CO₂.

Plant a tree. An average tree can absorb 1 ton of carbon dioxide over its lifetime.

The average US office worker goes through 10,000 sheets of copy paper per year. Print on both sides and in draft mode whenever feasible.

Did you know?

The average US citizen uses 50 pounds of tissue paper per year. Try to buy the highest content of post-consumer recycled content, looking for either 100% recycled or FSC-certified tissue or toilet paper.

Easy money



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Refrigerators account for one-sixth of a home's energy use. Opening the door accounts for between \$30 and \$60 of a typical family's electricity bill each year. Select energy-efficient models

when buying replacements.

Many idle electronics—TVs, DVD players, stereos, microwaves—use energy even when switched off to keep display clocks lit and remote controls working. Switch off power strips and unplug electrical devices when you're not using them.

Did you know?

US consumers spend up to 10,000 times more per gallon for bottled water than for tap water.